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Short Staffed

Dearth of senior police officers in states across the country

The latest annual report of the Union Home Ministry says that there is a massive shortage of senior police officers. The authorised strength of the Indian Police Service (IPS) is 4,013 while those in service number only 3,382. Even the 122 officers under training at the National Police Academy will find their initial postings at the entry level. Currently, at least seven states report a shortage of 40 or more IPS officers. Retired police officer S. Mariswamy, a former director-general of police in Karnataka, says, "Shortage of senior officers should be looked into immediately as vacancies at such a senior level mean hampering serious decision-making processes and these will in turn affect the functioning of ground troops and also lower their morale." Even as Union Home Minister P. Chidambaram has sought a report on the Dantewada massacre that claimed the lives of 76 CRPF men, another priority for him could be to make up the shortfall in senior police officials at the earliest.

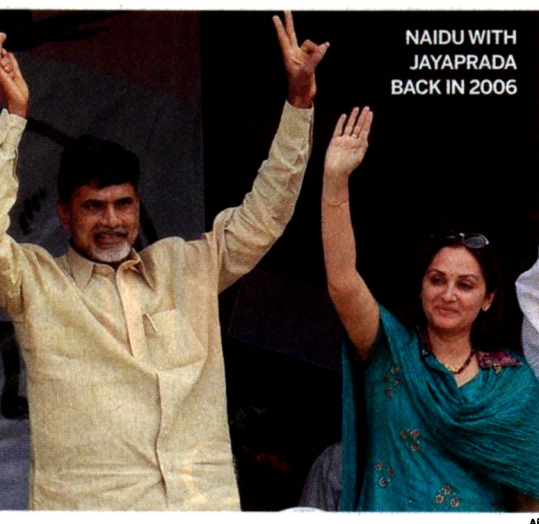
by Stephen David



After the Dantewada massacre, the Union Home Ministry is seriously contemplating a compulsory two-year stint for all Indian Police Service (IPS) officers with units involved in counter-insurgency operations.

HYDERABAD | Coming Full Circle

Former film actor and Samajwadi MP from Rampur, Uttar Pradesh, Jayaprada is finally looking at the party



NAIDU WITH JAYAPRADA BACK IN 2006

that had launched her—the Telugu Desam Party (TDP). This was the party that she joined in 1994 during the time of founder N.T. Rama Rao, but quit when N. Chandrababu Naidu parted ways. Later, she deserted Naidu for the Samajwadi Party on Amar Singh's insistence. Naidu is eager to add glamour quotient to the TDP Mahila wing, after another actor R.K. Roja quit. Jayaprada will have to take over the reins from TDP MLA Seetha Dayakar Reddy to help the party with its resurgence plans. She is willing but wants to be nominated by the TDP in the coming biennial elections to the Rajya Sabha. For Naidu, any induction with preconditions is an anathema but he just might give in for the sake of the TDP.

by Amarnath K. Menon

PATNA |

Lalu's Day Out

Rashtriya Janata Dal president Lalu Prasad's recent innocuous stroll in the Patna Zoo has kicked up a controversy. The reason: Lalu walked in with his armed security guards in apparent disregard of an order that prohibits carrying arms into zoo premises. The zoo authorities have now ordered an inquiry into the episode and the two guards who were

AJAY KUMAR



LALU AT THE ZOO

manning the zoo gates have been asked to give an explanation. The Patna Zoo, officially known as Sanjay Gandhi Biological Park, has been a favourite haunt of both VIPs and commoners for many years. But with officials sniping at his security men, Lalu may have to look for greener pastures elsewhere during an election year. The zoo is an excellent place to unwind and relax but not for Lalu, it seems.

by Amitabh Srivastava